

Word family: **tal** / taller / tallest

Base word: tal

Comparative: taller

Superlative: tallest

Part of speech: adjective

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **tal person**

* **tal building**

* **tal tree**

* **tal glass**

* **X metres/feet tal**

* **stand tal**

* **a tal order**

* **a tal tale**

* **walk tal**

Meaning in this passage

> He was quite **tal** and thin.

Here, **tal** means:

having greater than average height — 高的；個子高的

中文翻譯：

他身形頗**高**，也偏瘦。

So here:

tal = 身高較高的

1. **tal** (人：高個子的) — 高的；高個子的

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> He was quite **tal** and thin.

他身形頗**高**，也偏瘦。

Practice 2

> She is **tall** for her age.

以她的年齡來說，她算是很**高**。

Practice 3

> He is the **tallest** person in the family.

他是家中**最高的人**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tall = 身高比一般人高，或由底部到頂部的高度較大****

2. **tall building / tree / structure — 高的建築 / 樹 / 結構**

****Tall**** is also used for objects that extend a long way upward.

Practice 1

> They live in a **tall building**.

他們住在一幢**很高的建築物**裏。

Practice 2

> A **tall tree** stood beside the house.

屋旁有一棵**高大的樹**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tall = 從底部到頂部高度很大的，尤其用於較窄而向上延伸的人或物****

3. **X metres / feet tall — 高 X 米 / 呎**

Practice 1

> The tower is 60 metres **tall**.

那座塔有 **60 米高**。

Practice 2

> He is six feet **tall**.

他身高 **六呎**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****X metres/feet tall = 用數字表示某人或物的高度****

4. **tall glass / tall container — 高身的杯 / 容器**

Practice 1

> She poured the juice into a **tall glass**.

她把果汁倒進一隻**高身玻璃杯**。

Practice 2

> The flowers were arranged in a **tall vase**.

那些花插在一個**高身花瓶**裏。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tall = 高而相對窄長的****

5. **stand tall — 昂首挺立；有自信地站着**

This can be literal or figurative.

Practice 1

> He **stood tall** at the front of the room.

他在房間前面**挺直身子站着**。

Practice 2

> She **stood tall** despite the criticism.

即使受到批評，她仍然**昂首面對 / 保持自信**。

MCQ-ready definition:

stand tall = 挺直站立；也可比喻有自信、有尊嚴地面對困難

6. **walk tall — 昂首闊步；自信地做人**

Practice 1

> After winning the award, he seemed to **walk tall**.

獲獎後，他看起來更加**自信昂揚**。

Practice 2

> You should be proud and **walk tall**.

你應該感到自豪，**昂首自信地做人**。

MCQ-ready definition:

walk tall = 表現得自信、自豪、有尊嚴

7. **a tall order — 很難完成的要求 / 任務**

A very common idiom.

Practice 1

> Finishing all this work today is a **tall order**.

今天內完成所有工作是個**很難做到的要求**。

Practice 2

> Asking a beginner to master this in a week is a **tall order**.

要求初學者一星期內掌握這個技能，實在是個**很高難度的要求**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a tall order = 很困難、要求很高、不容易完成的事情

8. **a tall tale** — 荒誕故事；誇張得難以置信的故事

Practice 1

> He told us a **tall tale** about meeting a movie star.

他給我們講了一個關於遇見電影明星的**誇張故事**。

Practice 2

> I suspected the whole story was a **tall tale**.

我懷疑整件事只是個**荒誕不經的故事**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a tall tale = 明顯誇張、難以置信，通常帶娛樂性的故事

Important distinction 1: **tall** vs **high**

This is the most important contrast.

tall

usually describes something that has a significant vertical dimension and is relatively narrow:

- * tall person
- * tall tree
- * tall building

high

usually describes:

- * position above the ground
- * level
- * amount

> a **high** shelf
> 很高位置的架子

> a **high** price
> 高價

You normally say:

> a **tall man**

not:

> a high man

Important distinction 2: **tall vs long**

tall

vertical height.

long

length from one end to another.

> a tall building

高樓

> a long road

長路

Important distinction 3: **tall vs big**

big

overall size.

tall

height specifically.

A person can be:

* tall and thin

* short but big/heavy

So **tall** is much more precise.

Important distinction 4: **tall** vs **large**

large

overall dimensions or quantity.

tall

height only.

> a large room

大房間

> a tall tower

高塔

Important distinction 5: **tall** person vs **high** person

For people:

tall

correct for physical height.

high

does not normally describe a person's body height.

So:

> He is tall. 

> He is high. 

> (unless **high** means something completely different, such as intoxicated or positioned high up)

Important distinction 6: ****tall building vs high building****

Both can occur, but they differ in emphasis.

****tall building****

focuses on its vertical size.

****high building****

less natural in ordinary English; often ****high-rise building**** is preferred for very tall urban buildings.

So for learners:

prefer ****tall building****

Important distinction 7: ****tall glass vs big glass****

****tall glass****

high and relatively narrow.

****big glass****

large overall capacity/size.

They are not necessarily the same shape.

Important distinction 8: ****stand tall vs be tall****

****be tall****

physical height.

****stand tall****

literal posture or figurative confidence.

> He is tall.

他個子高。

> He stood tall.

他挺直身子 / 昂首面對。

Important distinction 9: **tall order** vs **difficult task**

Very close, but:

tall order

is idiomatic and emphasizes that the request is unusually demanding.

difficult task

simply means hard to do.

Important distinction 10: **tall tale** vs **lie**

lie

deliberate false statement intended to deceive.

tall tale

wildly exaggerated or unbelievable story, often told for entertainment.

So a tall tale can be playful rather than malicious.

Family-extension note

Tall has one strong literal core:

great vertical height

From that, several figurative expressions developed:

* **stand tall** → behave with confidence/dignity

* **walk tall** → feel proud/confident

* **tall order** → a very demanding task

* **tall tale** → an exaggerated story

So the literal sense is compact, while the idiomatic extensions are distinct enough to teach separately.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
-----	-----	-----
tall person	高個子的人	great height
tall building	高樓	vertically high
tall tree	高大的樹	vertically high
X metres tall	高 X 米	measured height
tall glass	高身杯	tall and narrow
stand tall	挺直 / 昂首面對	posture/confidence
walk tall	昂首自信地做人	pride/confidence
a tall order	高難度要求	very demanding
a tall tale	荒誕誇張故事	exaggerated story

For your original sentence

> He was quite ****tall**** and thin.

Here:

****tall = 身高較高的 ; 高個子的****

It is a straightforward physical-description sense.

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 他身形頗****高****，也偏瘦。

So the exact passage sense is simply ****greater than average in height****.